Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 5 – Information Management
(December 2020 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

This paper consisted of 20 multiple-choice (MC) questions. Candidates had to complete all the questions. The coverage of the questions was widely distributed among the topics of the syllabus as follows:

(a) Analyse the role of e-Commerce;
(b) Analyse the risks and security of information management;
(c) Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems;
(d) Describe and apply corporate information systems;
(e) Analyse systems development process and
(f) Use information technology applications.

Candidates' performance on the MC questions was good, as these questions are usually short and straightforward.

Specific Comments

Candidates showed weaknesses in the following areas:

(a) Analyse systems development process – how to account for and fund information systems;
(b) Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems – the definition of performance management; and
(c) Categorise the nature and account for the value of information systems – the information needs of the strategic level of management.

(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

This is a new module under the new qualification framework, and some of the topics are new to the candidates. Most candidates performed well in some general and fundamental topics, such as e-Commerce and the roles of accountants in a corporate information system. However, many candidates demonstrated weak performance in new topics or specific IT topics, such as artificial intelligence, dashboard, system development life cycle, user acceptance test, system selection process and performance management.

Specific Comments

Question 1(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to list and describe quality-related characteristics of data and information.

Performance was not satisfactory. Most candidates were not able to name the characteristics. Some candidates listed three different types of data instead. Moreover, some candidates used the requirements/keywords of data integrity, such as accuracy, completeness, and consistency, to develop their answers.

Question 1(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the roles of information systems.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Some candidates were not able to discuss the roles of information systems—instead, they discussed the usage of information systems among the three levels of management. Some candidates listed the advantages of information systems instead.

Question 1(c) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to outline some specific types of e-commerce activities that could be done by an online fashion store.

Performance was satisfactory. However, some candidates mentioned the types of "e-commerce", such as B2B, B2C, and/or B2G, instead of "e-commerce activities". Some candidates listed different marketing and advertising activities as three different types of e-commerce activities.

Question 1(d) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate and describe how companies in different industries provide conveniences to their customers via self-service functions.

Performance was good. However, some candidates mentioned the term "e-banking" only without elaborating what e-banking services could be conducted. Some candidates mentioned ATM services instead of the services provided by the websites and mobile applications.

Question 2(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to explain how accountants perform the roles of system designers and system auditors.

Performance was satisfactory.

Many candidates were able to point out that accountants can help identifying data be input and output along with some accounting rules as a system designer. However, a few candidates mentioned accountants' involvement in system design or related decision marking duties.

Many candidates were able to point out that accountants can perform accuracy checking as a system auditor. A few candidates mentioned the duties of checking for compliance. Not many candidates mentioned the collection and evaluation of evidence from an information system.

Question 2(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate the types of executive information needs in a human resources department and production department.

Performance was fair. However, some candidates simply listed some report names without any demonstration or explanation.

Question 2(c) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state examples to show how an information system could enhance continuous process improvement and organisational communication.

Performance was not satisfactory.

Many candidates focused on providing examples of "business analysis" instead of "continuous (business) process improvement" in the first sub-section. Many candidates described information systems as a collaboration tool in the second sub-section.

Question 3(a) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the reports which can monitor the performance of the existing accounting software.

Performance was not satisfactory. Many candidates answered incorrectly, mentioning the financial reports that could be generated by accounting software. Only a few candidates named the reports which can monitor system performance.

Question 3(b) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to identify the correct stage of the systems development life cycle among the given system development activities.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Many candidates were not familiar with the activities among the stages in the system development life cycle, and they were not able to match the correct stage with the given system development activities.

Question 3(c) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to explain why a user acceptance test should be completed before an ERP system is officially launched.

Performance was not satisfactory. Many candidates were not familiar with the topic of user acceptance tests as well as its corresponding importance to a system development project.

Question 3(d) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate some activities in selecting a suitable ERP system.

Performance was not satisfactory. The question focused on vendor selection activities, but many candidates described how to ensure smooth system implementation or how to make a buy or build decision.

Question 4(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define artificial intelligence (AI).

Performance was fair. However, some candidates described self-learning functions or machine learning, which is a sub-field of AI.

Question 4(b) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to contrast the difference between strong AI and weak AI.

Performance was not satisfactory. Some candidates discussed how to build a strong or weak AI, or they compared strong and weak AI in terms of data amount and complexity.

Question 4(c) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to state the capabilities of a performance dashboard.

Performance was less than satisfactory. Many candidates mentioned the advantages of using a performance dashboard rather than the capabilities.

Question 4(d) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate and describe how a business intelligence system presents two different situations with a dashboard.

Performance was not satisfactory. The question focused on how to present "an increase of net profit ratio" and "shortage of an inventory item" with a dashboard, but many candidates described how to discover and identify these matters from an information system.

Question 5(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to outline and describe three components of security policies.

Performance was poor. Many candidates mentioned the types of security policies rather than the components of security policies.

Question 5(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to classify and describe any three classes of data among non-governmental organisations.

Performance was less than satisfactory. There should be at least two different perspectives to classify the data into different classes or categories. These are (1) IT security perspectives and (2) big data perspectives. Without these classifications, it would be difficult to adopt appropriate IT security controls to protect them or use appropriate tool(s) to perform data analysis.

Question 5(c) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to demonstrate and describe limitations of using passwords for authentication.

Performance was fair. Many candidates mentioned the difficulty in memorising a password without an appropriate reason. Meanwhile, some candidates mentioned that the hackers could guess or grab a person's password easily without describing how they could do so.

(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

The overall performance of the candidates was less than satisfactory. Candidates are advised to familiarise themselves with the syllabus areas and their corresponding weighting before preparing for the examination. As the syllabus areas of “Risks and security of information management” and “Analysis of systems development process” are essential to this module, candidates should spend some time and effort to familiarise themselves with the topics in these two areas.

Candidates are reminded to read the questions carefully and address what is being asked. Be careful to identify the keywords in each of the questions. The answer is completely different between (1) “types of e-commerce” and “types of e-commerce activities”, (2) “roles of information systems” and “advantages of information systems” as well as (3) “types of security policies” and “components of security policies”.